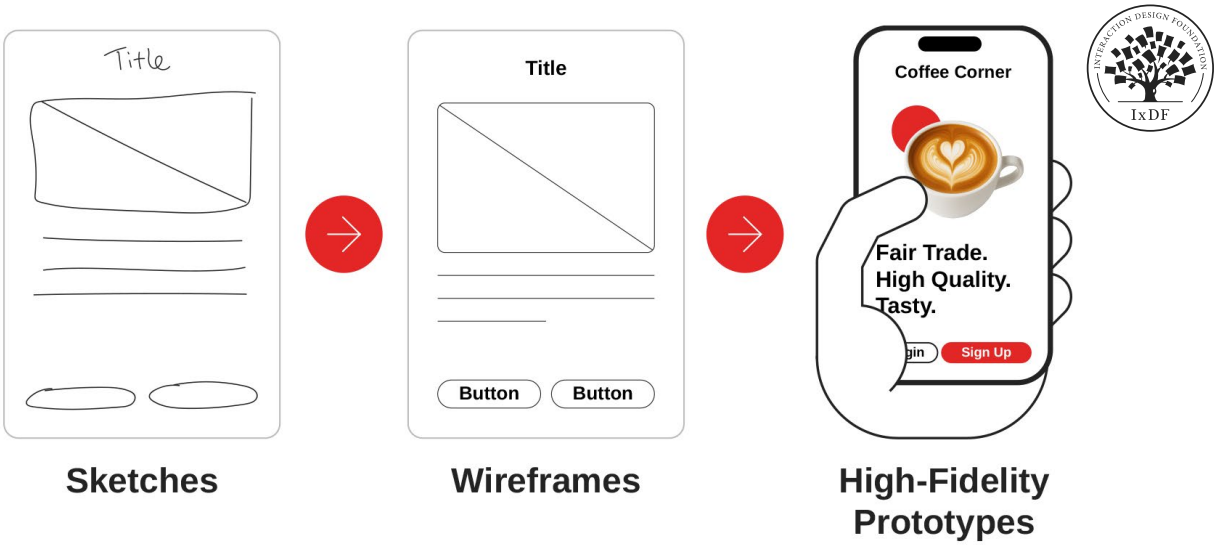

Choose Sketches, Wireframes, or Prototypes with Confidence

Frameworks for Visualization Selection

Visualization turns your ideas into shared understanding. The right visual at the right moment helps you explore, explain, and align faster without wasting effort polishing something that isn't ready.

This guide walks you through how to pick the most effective visualization for your current scenario. You can use it to balance effort against uncertainty, tailor your visuals to your audience, and apply just enough fidelity to move your project forward with confidence.

How To Use This Template

Use this template whenever you feel unsure about which visualization method to use in your current context. It'll help you focus your time where it matters most and make progress that feels purposeful, not perfectionist.

Start with the **Visualization Selection Guide** to decide your general visualization path: sketches, wireframes, or prototypes. Then use the **frameworks** that follow to refine your choice based on what your project needs most, like managing risk, matching your audience, or handling complex interactions.

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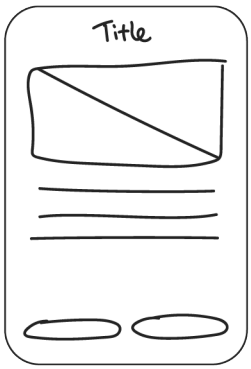
Types of Visualization

Visualization can take many forms, but in practice, you'll use four main types: sketches, wireframes, lo-fidelity prototypes, and hi-fidelity prototypes. Greater fidelity in visualization is not always better. Sketches are very rough but invaluable during ideation. Wireframes and lo-fidelity prototypes look unfinished, which reduces the reluctance that some may have to provide feedback. Each serves a different purpose.



Sketch

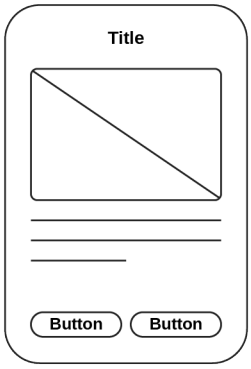
Sketches are valuable for comparative purposes. Sketches typically lack features, have little similarity to the finished product, and have minimal aesthetic refinement. Since they tend not to support interaction, this is shown in the chart as "Functions: None".

Features
Functions
Similarity
Aesthetics

Features, Similarity, Aesthetics: Low, Functions: None

Purpose: Explore early ideas quickly

Typical Use: Ideation and comparison of concepts



Wireframe

These are usually static representations of screen designs that have more features and greater visual similarity to the finished design than sketches. However, their aesthetic refinement is minimal; like sketches, they usually support no functionality. Wireframes can be hi-fidelity and in some cases, interactive. However, at this stage, they may be referred to as lo-fidelity prototypes.

Features
Functions
Similarity
Aesthetics

Features, Similarity: Moderate, Aesthetics: Low, Functions: None

Purpose: Define layout and structure

Typical Use: Reviewing screens and flows

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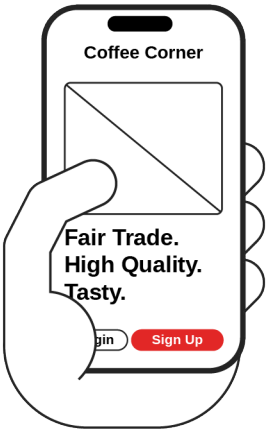

Lo-Fidelity Prototype

Prototypes are interactive and vary considerably in fidelity (how closely they resemble the finished product). Low fidelity is a good starting point, especially when you're testing with users, as it appears unfinished and will likely attract more suggestions for improvement. This is especially true of lo-fidelity prototypes in rough or hand-drawn styles.

Features
Functions
Similarity
Aesthetics

Features, Functions, Similarity, Aesthetics: High

Purpose: Test flow and usability early

Typical Use: User testing and iteration

Hi-Fidelity Prototype

Hi-fidelity prototypes closely resemble your finished solution in appearance. They typically offer more interactive functionality, especially since an interface that looks complete should behave as users expect. You can get away with less functionality in a lo-fidelity prototype, as expectations are lower.

Features
Functions
Similarity
Aesthetics

Features, Functions, Similarity, Aesthetics: Maximum

Purpose: Refine detailed design and visual style

Typical Use: Usability testing and developer handoff

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Start Here: The Visualization Selection Guide

This is your quick-start tool for deciding which visualization to use. For example, if you're designing a complex interaction that is new or you're unsure how to approach it, you should use multiple rounds of sketching, followed by wireframes, and then prototypes. This approach helps you mitigate risk by iterating on a design step-by-step, from low to high fidelity.

	Well-Understood	Some Uncertainty	High Uncertainty / Novel
Simple Interactions	Skip to Prototype	Wireframes	Sketches → Wireframes
Complex Interactions	Wireframes → Prototype	Sketches → Wireframes → Prototype	Multiple Sketch Iterations → Wireframes→ Prototype
Critical User Flows	Wireframes→ Prototype	Sketches → Wireframes → Prototype	Extensive Sketching → Multiple Wireframe Iterations → Prototype

Key: Skip to prototype = Jump directly to a higher-fidelity visualization; **→ =** Progressive refinement through visualization types; **Multiple iterations =** Several rounds at that fidelity level

Visualization Selection Guide (text version of table above)

Simple interactions

- **Well-understood:** Skip to prototype
- **Some uncertainty:** Wireframes
- **High uncertainty/Novel:** Sketches → Wireframes

Complex interactions

- **Well-understood:** Wireframes → Prototype
- **Some uncertainty:** Sketches → Wireframes → Prototype
- **High uncertainty/Novel:** Multiple sketch iterations → Wireframes → Prototype

Critical user flows

- **Well-understood:** Wireframes → Prototype
- **Some uncertainty:** Sketches → Wireframes → Prototype
- **High uncertainty/Novel:** Extensive sketching → Multiple wireframe iterations → Prototype

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Refine Your Approach: Four Visualization Frameworks

Below are four different frameworks you can use to refine your visualization choices further, depending on the scenario.

The **Risk-Driven Visualization Framework** helps you adjust your visualization effort based on design risk and uncertainty. Use this when you're not sure how much exploration your design needs before testing or implementation:

- **High uncertainty/novelty:** More visualization iterations (sketch → wireframe → prototype)
- **Well-understood patterns:** Jump to higher-fidelity visualizations
- **Complex interactions:** Interactive prototypes are essential
- **Simple CRUD (Create-Read-Update-Delete) operations:** Static wireframes are often sufficient

The **Audience-Driven Visualization Framework** helps you decide how polished or detailed your visualization should be based on who you're presenting to.
Use this when you're creating visualizations for feedback or presentation.

- **Self/team exploration:** Sketches and rough wireframes
- **Stakeholder alignment:** Clean wireframes with annotations
- **User validation:** Interactive prototypes
- **Development handoff:** Detailed visualizations (potentially high-fidelity)

The **Object-Centric Visualization Strategy** helps you determine what to focus on when visualizing object-oriented designs. Use this when your interface includes multiple related objects or dynamic relationships.

- **Core domain objects** → Visualize key interaction patterns early
- **Standard views (lists, forms, details)** → Use established patterns, minimal visualization
- **Novel views** → Extensive visualization exploration
- **Complex object relationships** → Focus on transition flows and state changes

The **Progressive Visualization Model** shows how visualization evolves throughout the design process. Use this when you're planning your next design iteration and need to know how much detail to add.

- **Concept validation** → Quick sketches of key scenarios
- **Interaction validation** → Wireframes for complex flows
- **Experience validation** → Prototypes for novel or critical interactions
- **Implementation validation** → Detailed specs for edge cases

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- **Craft your personal portfolio** with results that prove your value. You'll create career assets like conceptual models and design maps that show how you can move from requirements to **implementation-ready UIs that users love.**

Learn more about this course >

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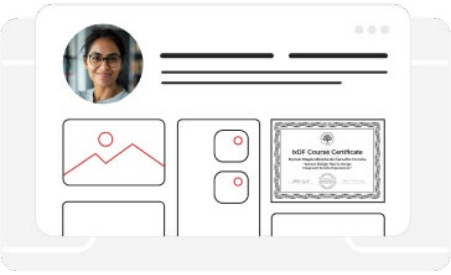

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